

DAIICT

Course Name: Approaches to Indian Society

Course Code: HM106

Credit: 3-0-0-3

Semester: Winter Semester 2026

Course Instructors: Dr Purbasha Das and Dr Ratna Bharati B

Course Outline

This course is an introduction, within a social scientific framework, to Indian social organization with special reference to its social forms and their genealogies. The course begins by foregrounding the emergence of India as a civilizational imaginary and nation-state within the narrative-historical framework of the region. The aim is to unpack the idea of the “unity” of India given the pluralism and diversity it ostensibly accommodates.

Historically, India has been interpreted as a nation of communities with well-established communal ways of living. This is reflected in its texts, habits of life, traditions, agrarian practices, social organization, political behaviour and several other aspects of social life. However, the advent of modernity has profoundly changed South Asian society. Colonial modernity has catalyzed socially and politically important changes in its social fabric, thus raising important questions. Was India always a region with fixed boundaries and identity, a stable and constant social organization, and settled communal modes of life? If so, in what ways pre-modern India was different from the present one? What sort of changes did colonialism bring about in Indian society? Is there an inherent civilizational dynamic to social life in India which is markedly different from the one that is found in Western societies? Did the nation-state India flatten out all of its myriad forms of diversity—communities, languages, cultures, lifestyles—and their historical origins? Or, did the social forms in India find new modes of articulation in conditions of modernity? More importantly, how is the history of the present to be understood because of what happened in South Asia in the last few centuries?

The course aims to find answers to these questions with the help of the decades-long social scientific scholarship now available. It would cover several relevant topics, such as colonial law and state, the formation of the public, colonial knowledge, village India, agrarian economy, peasant histories, caste and social structure, modernization, family and kinship, nationalism, communalism, and globalization.

Grading:

First In- Semester Examination - 30%

Second In-Semester Examination - 30%

Group Assignment - 40%

Course Objective:

This course aims to construct a comparative framework for the understanding of different cultures with particular reference to social organization, politics, religion and symbolism illustrated with various ethnographic examples. The course is designed to provide with the means to apply basic anthropological understandings of society and culture in the analysis of meanings, actions and explanations that is the basis for communication in the society. Students will be expected to reflect upon the Indian society utilizing the readings and lectures.

Course Outcomes: Upon passing the courses, students should have a:

- Basic critical and analytical understanding of how social and cultural diversity is approached in anthropology [PO1, PO7, PO12]
- How the diversity of culture, implicit in anthropological explanations, is to be understood [PO6, PO7, PO8].

POs-COs Matrix:

PO1	PO2	PO3	PO4	PO5	PO6	PO7	PO8	PO9	PO10	PO11	PO12
X					X	X	X				X

Course Outcomes and Competencies

Sr. No	Course Outcome	PO/PSO	CPD	KD
1	CO1: Basic critical and analytical understanding of how social and cultural diversity is approached in anthropology, sociology and history.	PO1, PO7, PO12/PSO1	U	F,C
2	CO2: How the diversity of culture, implicit in anthropological, sociological and historical explanations, is to be understood	PO6, PO7, PO8/PSO1, PSO2	U, Ap	F,C,P

CL: Cognitive Process Domain [R: Remember; U: Understand; Ap: Apply; An: Analyze; E: Evaluate; C: Create]

KC: Knowledge Domain [F: Factual; C: Conceptual; P: Procedural; M: Metacognitive]

Focus Area	Yes/ No	Details
Focus on Employability	No	-
Focus on Skill development	Yes	The students develop necessary skills to develop knowledge in

		culture, society and identity
Focus on entrepreneurship	No	-

Reading List

Richards, John F. "Early Modern India and World History."

Cohn, Bernard. "Notes on the History of the Study of Indian Society and Culture"

Metcalf, Barbara and Thomas Metcalf. "The East India Company Raj: 1772- 1850" from A Concise History of Modern India

Singer, Milton. "Beyond Tradition and Modernity in Colonial Madras"

Joseph R. Gusfield, 'Tradition and Modernity: Misplaced Polarities in the Study of Social Change,' *American Journal of Sociology*, Vol. 72, No. 4 (Jan., 1967), pp. 351- 362.

Cohn, Bernard. "From Indian Status to British Contract."

Ludden, David. "Modernity" from An Agrarian History of South Asia.

Anderson, Benedict. "The Origins of National Consciousness", excerpt from Imagined Communities

Geertz Balinese Cockfight

"Seven Prevalent Misconceptions about India's Caste System" in Diane P. Mines and Sarah E. Lamb (ed). *Everyday Life in South Asia*.

Anandhi S Women's Question in the Dravidian Movement c. 1925-1948

Anti-Arrack Agitation of Women in Andhra Pradesh. 4 March 2024